the Brahmputra basin to the Lohit district in the north, including a 2.1 kilometre-long bridge at Alubari Ghat, has been successfully pushed by us and would be a reality in five to seven years. This would reduce the journey from Tinsukia in Assam to Tezu in Arunachal from four hours (a whole day during the monsoon period) to an hour or two.

I have made it a habit to drive into the rural areas of the state to meet people and see the developments taking place in the interior areas. Travelling by helicopter does not offer the same opportunities. On weekends, we sometimes also go on excursions in the vicinity of Itanagar. On one such exploratory visit, we came across a beautiful valley with paddy fields on both sides of a small river. We started trekking along the river and walked uphill, leaving the road and a sleepy little village behind. The water flowing in the river was spring-fed as a large number of perennial streams originating from natural springs flowed into it. There were rain forests on both sides of the river. After walking for an hour along a forest trail, we spotted a nice place where the river formed a big pool. The water was emerald green and its attraction was difficult to resist. We decided to relax and enjoy nature's bounty. This was pure mineral water as there was no habitation uphill that could have polluted it. We enjoyed our picnic lunch and swam in the river. On our way back we stopped at the same small village. As was our practice, we distributed sweets among the children and spoke to the villagers. Besides agriculture they had no other source of income or means of livelihood. It was subsistence living. Except for electricity and an unmetalled road, not much had changed in their lives for decades. This village of around 300 inhabitants, about an hour's drive from Itanagar, is called Poma, and the river has derived its name from it.

In the absence of any industry or with tourism yet to see the light of day, some avenue had to be found to enable income generation. I had read of the Cane and Bamboo Technology Centre (CBTC) at Guwahati. On my next trip there, I decided to visit the CBTC and meet Kamesh Salam, its director. It was a revelation as I found an